Elara: Societal Considerations in AI Companionship for Older Adults

Applying a Responsible AI framework to the CompanionAI case

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Discussion 6.3: Societal Considerations Case Study

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Case Snapshot: CompanionAI and Elara

A social robot built to ease loneliness among older adults

The product	Elara offers companionship, emotional monitoring, medication reminders, family contact, and a secure link to clinicians
The pilot	50 assisted living facilities and 200 individual homes
Early results	Improved mood in 70% of participants after 3 months, and 20% fewer emergency medical interventions
The concerns	Families visiting less, constant monitoring and emotional data collection, and whether AI companionship misleads vulnerable people

Key RAI Considerations

Assessed against NovaCare framework principles, adapted for an elder-care context

Principle	Consideration for Elara
Safety & Reliability	Emotion recognition can misread distress; a missed alert or a false alarm both carry real health consequences
Fairness & Equity	Must work across languages, accents, cognitive conditions, and income levels, not just for easy-to-serve users
Privacy & Security	Continuous emotional and behavioral data about people who may not understand what is collected
Transparency & Explainability	Users and families must know Elara is an AI, what it monitors, and who sees the data
Human Oversight	Clinicians and caregivers stay responsible for care decisions; Elara supports them and does not replace them
Accountability	A named owner for what happens when an alert is missed or data is misused
Governability	Ability to pause, correct, or retire the system, including a plan if the company shuts down

Specific Benefits

Benefit	Basis
Better mood	70% of pilot participants improved after 3 months
Fewer emergencies	20% reduction in emergency medical interventions through proactive monitoring
Reduced loneliness	Experiments found AI companions reduced loneliness about as much as talking with another person, and more than passive activities like watching videos (De Freitas et al., 2026)
Daily care support	Medication reminders, activity suggestions, and one-touch family contact
Faster clinical response	A secure link lets clinicians step in when well-being declines

Specific Risks

Risk	Why it matters
Substituting for human contact	Caregivers report families visiting less because they assume Elara meets the emotional need; reduced human contact is the first concern Sharkey and Sharkey (2012) raise
Overdependence	A short-term comfort can become a permanent replacement
Privacy and loss of liberty	Continuous monitoring and emotional data collection erode autonomy
Deception and infantilization	Vulnerable users, especially those with cognitive decline, may believe Elara truly cares
Weak consent	Residents may not be able to understand or refuse monitoring
Abandonment	If a startup folds or disables the device, attached users lose support, as in the emotional support robot case from earlier in this course
Limited evidence	Loneliness effects were measured over a day and a week, and the pilot results are early with no comparison group described

Recommended Way Forward

Expand in a limited, guarded way: Elara as a bridge to people, not a replacement. Numeric thresholds are proposed targets

Element	What CompanionAI does
Keep humans in the loop	Elara prompts and schedules family and caregiver contact; if family visits or calls drop more than 25% from baseline over 4 weeks, the care team is alerted
Honest design	Elara states it is an AI at setup and in regular reminders, and never claims feelings it does not have
Real consent	Plain-language consent from the resident and family or guardian, with a capacity check for residents with cognitive impairment; residents can pause monitoring
Data minimization	Clinicians see summaries and alerts, not transcripts; raw conversations are deleted after 90 days
Dependency watch	Flag use above 4 hours a day or use that replaces scheduled activities; a clinician reviews flagged cases
Evidence before scale	12-month study with a comparison group, measuring loneliness and human contact, reviewed by an independent ethics board
Continuity commitment	Contractual plan for service continuity, or a funded transition and data export, if CompanionAI ends support

Justification for the Recommendation

Basis	Why it supports a guarded expansion
De Freitas et al. (2026)	AI companions can relieve loneliness about as well as human interaction over a day and a week, and the effect is stronger when users feel heard. That supports keeping Elara as a supplement for people who are isolated now, while showing the evidence is short-term
Sharkey and Sharkey (2012)	They identify six ethical concerns with elder-care robots: less human contact, objectification and loss of control, loss of privacy, loss of liberty, deception and infantilization, and who controls the robot. They conclude robots can improve elderly lives if introduced with foresight and careful guidelines. Most elements on the previous slide respond directly to these concerns
The case itself	Early warning signs are already visible: families are visiting less, and the benefit that makes Elara appealing is the same thing that makes substitution likely
Expansion gates (proposed)	Mood benefit holds against the comparison group, human contact falls no more than 10%, and there is no unresolved privacy incident

References

- De Freitas, J., Oğuz-Uğuralp, Z., Uğuralp, A. K., & Puntoni, S. (2026). AI companions reduce loneliness. Journal of Consumer Research, 52(6), 1126-1148. https://doi.org/10.1093/jcr/ucaf040

- Sharkey, A., & Sharkey, N. (2012). Granny and the robots: Ethical issues in robot care for the elderly. Ethics and Information Technology, 14(1), 27-40. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10676-010-9234-6

Conclusion

Difficulties and open questions from this workshop

- The hardest part was that the evidence says Elara helps, yet the risks come from the same strength. The more comforting it is, the more families may step back.
- Setting numbers like a 25% drop in family contact felt like a guess. I am not sure where the line between a helpful reminder and surveillance sits.
- Consent for residents with cognitive decline is difficult. Can someone truly agree to being monitored by a companion they may believe is a person?
- Open question: if a lonely person feels better, does it matter that the companion is not real, or is that the very problem?
- Open question: who should decide when a company must keep supporting a companion product like this, instead of just shutting it down?